

Introduction

Postmodernity has no single generally accepted definition. Therefore, in this work it is considered not as a single philosophical school, but as an analytical model of contemporaneity.

It should be noted that postmodernity is not a single philosophical current. Rather, postmodernity is understood as a symptom in which the traditional values of modernity - rationality, enlightenment, order, and the search for meaning - become problematic. In a broader sense, this concerns a transition to so-called flat ontology, when any hierarchical systems - beginning with public and social systems, that is, systems of power and morality, and ending with epistemological and metaphysical attempts to reduce knowledge of the world to a single foundation - are declared suspicious. In addition, one of the key features of postmodernity is the rejection of the traditional Cartesian subject-object scheme. The knowing or governing subject is no longer postulated as an external center, but rather dissolves into a flat network of mutual relations.

Among the key thinkers traditionally associated with the philosophy of postmodernity, one can name above all Deleuze and Guattari, Foucault, Baudrillard, Derrida, and Lyotard. In Deleuze and Guattari, the figure of the rhizome is important - a networked, decentralized structure instead of the modernist tree, center, and hierarchy. In Foucault - the understanding of power not only as a direct prohibition or command, but as a system of disciplines, norms, procedures, knowledge, and the distribution of the permissible. In Baudrillard - the analysis of simulacra and sign systems in which reality is increasingly replaced by models, images, and codes. In Derrida - the critique of the stable presence of meaning and the idea of the mobility of meaning. In Lyotard - distrust toward grand narratives as one of the signs of the postmodern condition.

Criticism of postmodernity usually comes down to describing it as degradation and disintegration, as the mechanical loss of meaning, and to ridiculing it. In popular perception, postmodernity is often reduced almost to an intellectual analogue of delirium - to a condition in which anything can be mixed with anything, without a concrete aim or productivity. In many respects, because of this approach, criticism loses its force: the opponent appears illusorily harmless. Supporters of postmodernity more often avoid this term, instead calling these tendencies simply contemporaneity, contemporary philosophy, or contemporary politics, media, and so on, declaring their convictions to be creativity, the struggle against grand narratives and totalitarianism, self-realization, and freedom.

In this work I proceed from the opposite thesis: postmodernity should be understood not only as the disintegration of previous forms, but also as a contemporary, highly effective, intellectually sophisticated system for organizing thought, power, and social life.

I will try to carry out critique and analysis not through ridicule, but through demonstrating that thinking in the paradigm of postmodernity has firmly entered everyday life precisely as a highly effective, flexible, self-reproducing, and total system - in the sense that it covers practically all spheres of human life.

Postmodernity does not destroy order, but produces an order of a new type: flexible, networked, procedural, semiotically mobile, and therefore especially suitable for contemporary forms of governance.

Postmodernity is a field of thought that draws in and digests external meanings. However, this is the capacity of any strong field of thought - the capacity to incorporate initially external meanings into itself. In the case of postmodernity, it is a matter of method - through the refusal of any stable aim and meaning, through the play with signs.

Postmodernity differs from modernity primarily in its form of organization. Modernity gravitates toward the center, hierarchy, the subject, a rational project, a great idea, and stable meaning. Postmodernity, by contrast, operates through the network, the protocol, the fragment, the flow, the interface, the procedure, and the situational assembly of meaning. Its power does not always appear as the power of a concrete ruler, class, or institution. It increasingly operates through the arrangement of the environment itself: rules of access, algorithms, ratings, standards, platforms, expert languages, and regimes of visibility.

Therefore postmodern power is not necessarily weaker than modern power. On the contrary, its effectiveness consists in the fact that it needs direct command less and less. It organizes space in such a way that the subject itself begins to

act in accordance with the given rules: to compete, adapt, demonstrate loyalty, produce the necessary signs, manage its own visibility, and constantly confirm its inclusion in the system.

The same applies to meaning. If modernity sought to attach the sign to a stable meaning, truth, essence, or function, then postmodern logic shows meaning as an effect of differences, context, and repeated use. Meaning does not disappear, but it ceases to be definitively fixed. It is assembled situationally from already existing fragments, quotations, codes, images, and semantic residues.

That is precisely why postmodernity cannot be reduced to chaos or decay. Its strength consists not in the absence of order, but in the production of a new type of order. It is an order without a single center, power without a necessary direct command, meaning without final fixation, and a system capable of including even its own critique within itself.

Internet and Media

Beginning with the era when the first mass media emerged - above all newspapers - the media were either an instrument of power itself or a means of struggle against power. The key instrument of modern power is censorship, that is, control over the channels through which information is distributed.

The era of modernity still presupposes work with meaning as its main instrument. The main instrument of propaganda here is the silencing of facts, direct lies, or an ideologically predetermined interpretation of events. At the same time, in its form, propaganda - that is, the use of the media by power for its own purposes - still remains analytical and logical. The media of modernity pass through censorship by the state or are directly subordinated to it. The number of print publications, radio stations, and television channels is fairly limited, and journalists are usually professionals integrated into a hierarchical structure.

The struggle against the propaganda of alternative political or foreign-policy forces consisted mainly in creating alternative, underground media channels: illegal radio stations, leaflets, samizdat, rumors, political communities, and circles. What matters is that in the era of modernity the source of control is subject-like: control or struggle takes place with a concrete person, organization, or political force. Therefore, honest competition among political forces in modernity is understood above all as a prohibition on censorship and restrictions on the transmission of information.

Modernity was accused of totality. The state controls the information field and pro-government narratives, and therefore its own legitimacy, through central channels and through the apparatus of censorship.

Contemporary media are well described by the paradigm of postmodernity. This is no longer a traditional hierarchical system directly controlled by power or by forces struggling against power, but a networked, formally flat environment implemented through platforms for publishing content and through social networks.

As an instrument of propaganda, online media become much more effective than traditional centralized media. Formally, anyone can publish content. At the same time, the key instrument of manipulation is no longer so much the concealment of facts, nor analysis that is at least logical in form, but rather replication, emotional manipulation, community support, memes, collages, and juggling with signs and fragments of meanings.

The number of likes becomes more important than argumentation itself and the quality of content. Arguments and facts simply drown in repeated slogans, collages, memes, and their endless replication. An alternative point of view, even if it is impeccably built on facts and argumentation, can be declared toxic or propaganda simply because it has few likes and lacks community support.

Here the effect of information bubbles arises. In postmodernity, algorithms do not necessarily have to delete an alternative point of view, as the censorship of modernity did. It is enough simply not to show it to those who disagree with it. Society breaks up into isolated capsules, each of which has its own "truth."

At the same time, the mechanism of content promotion is connected not only with politics, but also with the attention economy. Algorithms promote memes, emotions, conflicts, and outrage because this keeps the user at the screen. Negative emotions, radicalization, and arguments increase engagement, and therefore make it possible to sell more advertising.

In this sense, cancel culture becomes a characteristic postmodernist instrument of control. Instead of the state tribunal of modernity, there operates a "court of the crowd" based on emotional outrage. It can destroy a reputation and deprive a person of access to platforms without a direct state prohibition.

Post-truth is also an important sign of such a media environment. Truth here is not so much hidden, as in modernity, as devalued because of an excess of informational noise. As Jean Baudrillard wrote: there is more and more information, and less and less meaning.

Platform owners no longer need to find talented analysts and journalists. It is enough to promote content advantageous to the platform and to pessimistically downgrade the undesirable. At the same time, they are largely freed from responsibility and accusations of censorship. Online media can always be declared subjectless, and one can refer to impersonal algorithms, the business model, or the reaction of users.

In addition, postmodernity redefines the very concept of censorship. Not every restriction on media is declared censorship, but only state restriction or restriction by a "toxic" power. Whereas even direct restriction of alternative sources by platforms is declared to be a "struggle against toxic content" and "propaganda."

An important property of contemporary media is the fluidity characteristic of postmodernity not only in the semantic sense, but also in the infrastructural sense. It is often already difficult to separate media as an information channel from a business sales channel or a political platform. Shows, memes, media images, and collages become not an instrument serving politics, but politics itself.

For example, U.S. President Trump uses his Twitter/X channel to publish memes and short messages as political statements instead of a traditional diplomatic press service. At the same time, he uses his political image in online media to solve personal business tasks and sells political symbolism as merch. Another example is the use of relatives' social media channels to transmit controversial political messages.

Through the example of the media, one can understand that their contemporary form is by no means disintegration and degradation if they are considered primarily as an instrument of business and power. It is a technically and organizationally sophisticated system possessing great flexibility and effectiveness. At the same time, it allows its beneficiaries to hide from counterattack by concealing their subjecthood behind the network, the algorithm, and the protocol, and also to avoid accusations of control and censorship.

Politics

The politics of traditional society was closely connected with the clergy. Religious leaders largely legitimized wars and political decisions.

With the onset of the era of modernity, the nation became the key political unit, and the political platform began to be justified theoretically - through rational, philosophical, and ideological constructions. Models of a just and effective society were created theoretically and promoted among the people through education and enlightenment.

The politics of modernity relies on a developed philosophical and theoretical platform. Thus, the French Revolution was intellectually prepared by the philosophers of the Enlightenment - Voltaire, Rousseau, Montesquieu, and others. The idea of the nation-state was developed in different forms by Herder, Fichte, Hegel, and in the political practice of the nineteenth century by Mazzini and other national thinkers.

The idea of the nation was one of the key instruments of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries for justifying the redrawing of borders: the division of empires and the struggle of peoples for self-determination, for example during the "Springtime of the Peoples," or unification - above all Germany and Italy.

The theoretical basis of Marxist communism - one of the ideologies of modernity - was developed by Marx, who, in turn, radically reworked Hegel's dialectic. Fascism - another ideology of modernity - also did not arise out of nothing: on the one hand, as a political response to liberalism, parliamentarism, and communism, and on the other, as a radical reworking of the ideas of the nation, the state, mass mobilization, social Darwinism, and appropriated Nietzschean motifs.

The politician of modernity is largely an orator who uses rational arguments and relies on a developed theoretical platform. The politics of modernity values tradition, diplomacy, adherence to agreements, and in its ideal type is organized as a vertical ontological system.

By contrast, contemporary postmodern politics relies not on rationality and system, but on fragmentation and situationality. Not on rational arguments, but on narratives assembled from fragments of grand meanings and on emotional pressure. In postmodern politics, long-standing reputation is less important than the current news background. In the era of postmodernity, the significance of stable agreements also declines: their current interpretation in the media environment becomes more important.

The postmodernist leader does not so much inherit a ready-made doctrine as assemble meaning from the current context; his thinking is more playful than logical. He does not so much think in the form of an ideological system as build narratives. He is not a classical-type orator, but a showman. His speech is directed not so much at world leaders - aristocrats and intellectuals from the same milieu as himself - as at the masses. Indicative leaders of this type are Trump and Zelensky. It may sound as if postmodernity invented demagoguery and chaos. However, something else is important here: a politician of this new type is fully accepted by society and legitimized by the system.

In postmodern politics, the governance of the state becomes inseparable from media, the entertainment industry, and digital platforms. If the formula of modernity sounded like "Knowledge is power," then the formula of postmodernity is "Everyone has their own truth." In this environment, politics shifts the emphasis from strategy to effect, from doctrine to event, from ideological program to managed impression. The politician of the new type acts as a media node: he must continuously produce presence, hold attention, and generate reaction. Strategy does not disappear completely, but it dissolves into continuous management of visibility. Politics turns into simulation and media production, where what matters is not so much facts as the virality of the narrative.

In order to understand how the Western world came to this paradigm, it is necessary to turn to the philosophical foundation of postmodernity. If modernity relied to a significant degree on Hegel and Marx, then contemporary left-liberal politics partially inherits a line connected with the ideas of Jacques Derrida and his method of deconstruction.

Derrida showed that Western metaphysics is built on privileged distinctions and asymmetrical binary oppositions: presence/absence, speech/writing, male/female, center/periphery, norm/periphery, white/black. In such pairs, one element is usually regarded as principal, full, and primary, while the second is regarded as secondary, derivative, or subordinate. Deconstruction was conceived as an analytical method for revealing and undermining these hidden hierarchies. However, when it moves into the plane of political activism - what today is often called woke culture - this method often turns not into liberation from hierarchies, but into a technology for reassembling power.

The old binary opposition is exposed and inverted, but then a new norm - for example, inclusive/toxic, oppressed/privileged, progressive/reactionary - is fixed administratively, medially, and morally. This new coordinate system is no longer subject to deconstruction: it becomes an unquestionable dogma. That is, the method conceived as the exposure of hidden power in language begins to work as an instrument for producing new power.

It was precisely through this philosophical transformation that the astonishing fusion of the left political movement and global capitalism took place. In the 1970s, a significant part of continental philosophy, relying on reinterpreted Marx and Freud, shifted its focus from the classical Marxist class struggle to a struggle against all vertical hierarchies, patriarchy, and the oppression of minorities. The idea arose of a flat, networked world without rigid authorities - the "rhizome" in Deleuze and Guattari and power as a distributed network of practices and procedures in Foucault.

Paradoxically, this left, anti-hierarchical model of thinking largely coincided with the way contemporary transnational corporations are structured and think. Corporate culture actively supported the woke agenda, feminism, and the defense of minorities because they exist in the same field of thought: flexibility, fluidity, refusal of rigid verticals, constant reassembly of identities and rules. The class threat to big business was removed: economic protest was redirected into the channel of cultural deconstruction.

As a result, a paradoxical political picture emerged: contemporary leftists in the United States and Europe speak the language of social justice, which has become the official ideology and language of big corporate business. The right, by contrast, increasingly appears as the defender of small and medium-sized business, traditional institutions, and resistance to bureaucratic corporate pressure.

Today the woke agenda is not simply informational noise or the whim of radicals. It is an extremely important ritual of loyalty and part of the systemic code of corporate and state governance. That is precisely why formulas appear in American political rhetoric such as Joe Biden's statement about transgender people as the "soul of America." This is not so much concern for concrete people as a declaration of fidelity to a new political ontology in which the erasure of traditional boundaries is declared the highest good.

This civilizational shift is most vividly manifested in the approach to forming the human being. In the era of modernity, education was strictly hierarchical. School and the army instilled discipline, the cult of science, and national identity. Their task was to forge a citizen with a rigid moral and logical core.

In the era of postmodernity, the main values become flexibility, fluidity, and the ability to integrate into a networked environment. Rigid structures are recognized as "toxic." In this paradigm, LGBTQ+ and gender theory play a key role not only as questions of sexual orientation, but as a manifesto of fluid thinking. The refusal of biological sex becomes a symbolic refusal of the last natural binary oppositions and absolute narratives. To be "fluid" means the ideal ability of the subject to adapt to the fluid platform reality of postmodernity, which has no center and no strict boundaries.

Globalism and Postmodernity

In modernity, the nation is an instrument for legitimizing the state and power. In modernity, the nation is a multitude of people united - almost sacrally - on the one hand by a single language and by what is called folk culture - fairy tales, mythology, tradition, and the territory on which they live - and on the other by common economic, almost corporate interests that unite them into a state.

In this sense, Nazism is not a malfunction and not an accident, not an evil brought from outside by someone, but one of the extreme moves of modernity. Nazism is one of the peaks of the idea of modernity at the limit: the nation declared the highest value. Formally, a cult of rationality, science, and technology is proclaimed - including through the demonstrative sacrifice of humanism, the consideration of the human being as a biological object, an animal, the adaptation of Darwin's ideas to politics, and their reworking into racial theory and social Darwinism. For Hegel, history is the self-unfolding of the world spirit, which proceeds through peoples, through the Volksgeist, through concrete nations as through the steps of a ladder. "The existence of the state is the march of God in the world; its foundation is the power of reason actualizing itself as will." The Nazis take this idea to the limit as a political instrument, affirming the myth of the thousand-year Reich and Germany as the finale of the "divine march."

At the same time - outwardly paradoxically - the elite preaching cold rationalism is simultaneously drawn to mysticism, runes, Aryan myths, and rituals. This is not accidental, because myths and folk culture in modernity are an instrument for legitimizing the nation and the state.

The contemporary liberal-conservative tradition asserts that the "spirit of the West" is individual freedom. However, in Hegel - one of the key thinkers of the West - in the Philosophy of Right: "Freedom is the truth of necessity." That is, a person is free precisely to the extent that he consciously subordinates his will to the rational will of the state/people (Volksgeist). Thus one of the key accusations against Nazism - the suppression of individual freedoms for the sake of a common goal - is also one of the central ideas of Western thought embodied at the limit.

It is important to note here that every viable thought, every capable ideology, is total. This means that it unfolds on all levels of the social system - some parts logically support others. Of course, for the most part people do not sit with a philosophical or economic handbook and check their own logic of decision-making against it - rather, these are automatisms inside the field of the unfolding of the thought itself.

The history of the trial of Nazi criminals is indicative here. They behaved quite confidently before the court, being convinced that the very possibility of such a court undermined the idea of the state as the basic unit of the world order. Thus, the idea that citizens of a country acting in its interests could be subject to judgment seemed to them not merely debatable, but something that undermined the very order of the world and weakened the power of the victors rather than strengthened it, which made them potentially immune from judgment in their own eyes.

Nevertheless, they were judged with all severity, which was, of course, not the cause, but one of the early symptoms of the decline of modernity. A little later Hannah Arendt proposed the concept of totalitarianism - in itself humanistic and liberal, but one that became one of the key instruments for the moral delegitimation of the opponent and the

reorganization of the world. The enemies of the free world were no longer full-fledged competitors, but less legitimate.

Although, if one looks more broadly, total orders existed before as well: in the era of tradition the world also subordinated the human being - his way of thinking, morality, economy, power, private life as a whole - through religion, sacred order, and ritual. The difference with modernity here is that totality was derived not through rationalized meaning, but through religious sacredness. Postmodernity arises precisely at the peak of modernity, when it finds there a tradition that has not been completely overcome. It is interesting that the West, as it were, brackets off its own "children" - Nazism and communism - and declares them to be something external, something that allegedly was never part of it.

Globalism is already the era of postmodernity, when the idea of the state is overcome not through direct abolition, but through the extremely productive instruments of postmodernity itself. "Suspicion toward grand narratives" makes any more or less formed meaning too total, and therefore meaning is increasingly replaced by plastic form. The concepts of nation, borders, and sovereignty do not disappear, but become plastic, playful, mobile instruments. For example, in Ukraine marker-slogans are established - "Ukraine above all" - an obvious calque from "Deutschland über alles," with playful allusions toward Nazism, while on the other hand Nazism is declared to be above all "attacking other countries." On the one hand, it is said that Ukraine is the country of Ukrainians and that every effort must be made so that the Ukrainian language is the main and only language; on the other hand, it is said that the country must integrate into the general system. The example of Ukraine is not singular: the priority of national legislation and national interests is declared simultaneously with the conviction that "international laws" have priority over national ones. This is not necessarily hypocrisy - it is the normal logic of postmodernity, where contradiction ceases to be a malfunction and becomes a working mode.

The key point here is not separate contradictions, but international cooperation. Inter-corporate ties and interests begin to compete with interstate ones not only in meaning, but also in real force of action. Often it is no longer possible to determine unambiguously what strategy and whose interests a given state is pursuing.

The contemporary structure of the world is not a supranational government, not a shadow center, and not a single headquarters. It is distributed. Yes, there are powerful centers of force, but they do not form a single vertical. Interests are competed for simultaneously by states, corporations, the global interests of various industries as communities of professionals serving them, theological concepts, and ways of organizing society such as Islam, as well as secular adaptations of theocracy such as Zionism. For the most part, there are no global analytical centers. There are no concrete globalists in the form of individual persons, secret societies like the "Masons," or "Epstein's clients." Global financial companies also do not belong to one concrete person - rather, they are a network into which owners of financial assets with very different interests are included. The system self-unfolds according to its own internal laws, in which form productively dominates meaning. In globalism there really is no single coordinating center, no stable final meanings and aims.

Globalism supports itself because it corresponds to the interests of a huge number of people. Most industries that today provide the masses with labor and capital - education, production, capital, work processes, corporate culture - in their present scale can exist only globally. Therefore globalism replicates and reproduces itself not only through external forms, but also through the practice of thinking itself.

Every strong thought is total. The difference between epochs lies not in the presence or absence of totality, but in its mechanism. Modernity totalizes through meaning - the nation, the state, history, progress. Postmodernity totalizes differently - through form, network, procedure, compatibility, and the productive absence of a single obligatory meaning. Globalism, therefore, is not the disintegration of order, but a new, more flexible and effective total assembly of the world.

Post-Capitalism

The economy cannot be reduced only to the means of production (Marx), technologies, and institutions. It is always also held together by ethics - by stable ideas about permissible, just, obligatory, and worthy behavior. It is not by chance that in the USSR the necessity of a "new man" was proclaimed. The economy is above all the organization of

shared being and the distribution of goods. The functioning of an economic system without stable rules of behavior in society is impossible.

Another example of how dependent the economy is on ethics is the difficulty of transferring people between different ethical and social regimes into the economic system of Western countries. Cultures in which loyalty to the community, religious or family clan has great importance are more difficult to integrate into the impersonal ethics of corporate or state administration.

Classical capitalism rested on Protestant ethics. Weber successfully showed this in his classic work *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*. The theology of Protestantism presupposes the absolute will of God over the human being, and therefore God already knows whether a person will be saved or not. Accordingly, signs of future salvation can already be found in the present life. Protestantism encourages thrift, modesty, discipline, and hard work. In combination with the ideas of the free market, the successful entrepreneur is not simply a person who has achieved material success, but also someone marked by God during life, carrying an almost sacred meaning of justice.

Ayn Rand's objectivism (*Atlas Shrugged*) shifted this ethical form somewhat, partly desacralizing it, but adding pathos. In her work, the entrepreneur is not someone marked by God and saved in advance, but a hero of progress: an exceptional personality who, by his talent, will, and capacity for creation, moves the world forward and therefore receives the moral right to power, property, and reward.

The ethics of classical capitalism is the foundation and a key part of the entire system. The world order, the universe itself, as it were, rewards the entrepreneur for his virtues: hard work, the ability to take risk upon himself, talent, responsibility, respect for the impersonal rule and the contract.

Post-capitalism outwardly resembles classical capitalism, but fundamentally differs from it precisely because of a different ethics. Ethics in postmodernity is flexible and fluid and is based not on religious ethics and not on the ideas of modernity, but above all on the current needs of business, using the classical values of capitalism as a set of symbols and assembling from them, semiotically and locally, the relevant meanings.

In the capitalism of late modernity, roles still remained relatively separated. Initiative, the will to take risk, organizational talent, and the ability to create something new were demanded of the entrepreneur; possible power and money were understood as a just reward for risk and responsibility. The hired worker occupied a different but socially recognized position. He was not required to be the entrepreneur of his own life. He had a right to labor, a profession, a wage, a stable place in the production system, and the basic reproduction of life.

This was one of the important justifications of industrial modernity: the inclusion of the human being in a complex production system had to give him more than direct self-reproduction through simple forms of labor, crafts, trades, or subsistence farming. The point is not that pre-capitalist life was necessarily harder or worse. The point is that a person of average abilities there still had more direct access to the means of subsistence. Capitalism, however, justified the loss of this direct autonomy by giving the ordinary person a higher level of predictability, comfort, protection, and social reproduction.

In postmodernity, roles already begin to mix. Entrepreneurial skills are required of the hired worker - the ability to negotiate, self-presentation, innovativeness, the requirement to take on risk, and hyper-motivation. At the same time, double morality and the separation of roles remain: the worker must be devoted to the cause and the company and be passionate about work, whereas for the company he is an impersonal human resource, above all bringing profit and above all satisfying the requirement of rapid interchangeability.

In other words, what used to be a property of the entrepreneur now becomes a minimum requirement for the ordinary worker. Modernist capitalism promised the average person a life above simple self-reproduction. Postmodernist capitalism increasingly demands entrepreneurial qualities from the average person merely in order to preserve access to the basic level of life.

The startup industry functions in a similar way. Symbolically, the classical scheme operates: the entrepreneur brings innovation to the market and, in the event of success, receives a deserved reward. But the meaning of what is happening is inverted. It is increasingly advantageous for corporations not to produce the entire cycle of risk internally. Millions of teams, startups, and independent developers independently test ideas, products, niches, and business models. The corporation joins later - when the risk has already been partly removed and the promising

model has become visible. It buys not an abstract idea, but a result already filtered by the market. Founders have no other choice - because sales channels, infrastructure, advertising networks, cloud services, and access platforms are increasingly concentrated among large players.

Here one can note that mass culture restructures itself in time according to the needs of the market. For example, at the end of the 1980s, the image of the "street girl/boy" was popular, embodied in popular musical or cinematic images. The rapid change of dynamics in IT is indicative: if in the early 1990s the image of the punk/hacker was popular, in the 2000s it was the image of the successful yuppie bank worker, and in the 2010s already the urban resident/hipster - because at different stages of market development, the labor resources most necessary for the market were required.

In other words, mass culture does not simply reflect the labor market, but produces desirable types of subjectivity: the disciplined worker, the creative freelancer, the successful office professional, the flexible startup founder, the "special" urban specialist for whom work becomes part of identity.

Current labor-market requirements also change the requirements placed on ethics and values. If industrial culture could still separate labor from leisure, work from private life, profession from identity, then postmodernist culture increasingly joins them together. The worker must not simply perform a function, but be a certain type of subject: creative, flexible, passionate, special, constantly included in work, and ready to turn his own personality into part of the production process.

There is no need to look for a conspiracy here - the producers of media products simply read the current cultural layer. The cultural system supports itself, and even in the lower social strata people support the values of their own stratum for their own actualization and self-identification: falling out of a social model is often harder than being fixed at its bottom.

Direct coercion in the contemporary labor system does not disappear, but changes form. The worker is now governed not only by the boss and not only by the classical production hierarchy, but by the protocol: KPI, rating, the algorithm for distributing orders, platform, brand, license, corporate procedure. Power becomes not personal, but systemic. It operates through the rules of admission, evaluation, visibility, and interchangeability.

In traditional capitalism, the hired worker occupied a relatively stable place in the hierarchy: he had a position, a role, a wage, a boss, an enterprise, and at least minimally defined social obligations on the part of the employer. In the postmodernist model, this place becomes blurred. The worker must increasingly behave like an entrepreneur: be mobile, communicative, flexible, ready for risk, able to sell himself, constantly learn, and invest in his own "competitiveness." But at the same time he does not receive the main benefit of entrepreneurship - the possibility of appropriating substantial profit from the risk taken.

Here a characteristic simulacrum of entrepreneurship arises. The worker bears risks like an entrepreneur, but remains constrained as a hired worker. He himself pays for training, adaptation, promotion, equipment, downtime, reputational losses, and periods of decline. However, his income is limited from above by the logic of survival: he rarely reaches the level at which the worker himself can exit dependence and use someone else's hired labor. If the entrepreneur in classical capitalism takes risk for the sake of the possibility of profit, then the contemporary worker takes risk for the sake of preserving access to the system.

It is precisely here that a new form of power manifests itself. Business increasingly sells not so much a workplace as access to a protocol: to a brand, platform, marketplace, franchise, order algorithm, rating system, or corporate infrastructure. The risks remain below - with the courier, freelancer, seller, franchisee, content creator, application developer, remote worker. The upper level of the system extracts profit from the very organization of competition. It does not necessarily participate in each concrete risk, but it controls the rules of the game, the visibility of participants, and the possibility of exclusion from the system.

This is especially clear in digital and platform environments. In the real market, the entrepreneur suffers defeat as a result of competition: he loses if his product, price, or organization proves ineffective. But in the platform environment a different type of dependence appears. The platform owner possesses an almost sovereign right of access: he can change the algorithm, block an account, hide search output, cancel monetization, close an application, delete a shop, or nullify accumulated reputation. The efforts invested can thereby be annulled not by the market, but by the decision of the owner of the environment.

Therefore the contemporary model of labor looks entrepreneurial only outwardly. It imitates freedom of competition, initiative, and self-management, but preserves the asymmetry of power. The subject is offered the chance to be an entrepreneur without property, an investor without control, a participant in the market without the right to determine the rules of the market. This is what the postmodernist form of capitalist power consists in: it does not simply exploit labor, but organizes an environment in which the worker voluntarily takes on the risks necessary for the profit of the system.

That is precisely why postmodernist capitalism does not simply continue the exploitation of labor in the old form. It changes the ethical frame of labor itself. The ordinary person no longer simply sells labor power. He must constantly prove his own suitability for the system, invest in himself, manage his own reputation, accept risks, and fight for access to infrastructure that he does not own.

The modernist system promised the human being: enter production - and you will receive more than you could receive through direct self-reproduction.

The postmodernist system increasingly says something different: enter the race so as not to lose the very possibility of survival inside the system.

Work Processes and Management Technologies

Traditional society is usually built on estates - social roles are rigidly fixed - sometimes to the limit, as in the castes of India; more often, although theoretical possibility was present, the possibility of social migration was nevertheless more often limited. Despite this, the severity of the condition of the lower estates is still somewhat exaggerated: in order for the social system to reproduce itself, complete arbitrariness toward the poorest estates was rare, since working hands were a valuable resource for the more well-to-do estates or castes if there was no stable inflow from external sources such as slaves. Under conditions of low labor productivity, motivation was built on a deep awareness of one's place in life and on the stability of the reproducibility of all classes and estates. Power in tradition is always direct and physical - for the lower strata this means hunger, physical punishments, and minimal living conditions.

Modernity is built on rationality and ideas of progress. Unlike postmodernity, it offers at least formally a plan and an aim. For example, in the USSR this was the construction of communism, or the American dream in the form of one's own house and a large family. What matters is that the life scenario in modernity is clearly prescribed, and the performance of certain actions - such as getting an education or changing one's place of residence - gave a more or less predictable result.

Contemporary "corporate culture" also exists largely in the field of postmodernity. Power here is not direct, immediate, and hierarchical, but formally flat, friendly, and at the same time impersonal. Decisions are made not by the manager, but by a faceless process. The key point is that today work processes are often not built by the company itself, but are maximally unified and belong to the industry as a whole. This is needed for better control through common standards, rapid integration of the employee into work processes, and the ease of replacing him. In essence, the ease of replaceability is a strengthening of power over personnel. Often it is precisely the ability to integrate into global unified business processes that becomes a priority compared with real qualification, motivation, and personal abilities. A talented line employee is often less preferable than a mediocre one if he is a "one-off item."

Corporate culture actively uses the postmodernist play with signs and the local establishment of meaning. For example, employees who successfully integrate into the process are called leaders. Hiring and recruiting staff for a position that does not necessarily require talent or unique qualities, but is rare in the market - for example, because of a rarely demanded skill - is called a "challenge" or a "competition": the worker must be proud that he managed to close a personnel gap. Introduction to the state of affairs is called "training" - a kind of bonus. Fulfilling established work plans is called "ambitions." Corporate processes are maximally depersonalized and total: they are established not even by a separate corporation, but by the industry as a whole, and the corporation itself is included in it only as an articulation of the general machine. At the same time, maximally personal and emotional terminology is used: "toxicity," "engagement," "soft skills."

The immediate manager cannot be caught in hypocrisy here, because power is possessed by the total and faceless "industry." Inside, the corporation may look like an engineering device with processes, a business machine, but

through the system of recoding symbols the worker must see it as something maximally personal, life-forming, with a deep emotional connection.

Financial System

Cryptocurrencies, bitcoin, are a good illustration of the fact that the philosophy of postmodernity (post-structuralism) is applied even to the creation of financial systems. The very concept of bitcoin already contains a postmodernist concept: the notion of money can be redefined, and control is subjectless, flat, carried out through a network and protocol rather than through traditional issuance controlled by the state.

The example of bitcoin excellently demonstrates the postmodernist play with symbols and fragments of meaning. Thus, bitcoin is called "digital gold," thereby instilling the conservatism and reliability that come from a traditional means of payment. The media discuss ways of promoting "cryptocurrencies" - for this, they lack state control. And few pay attention to the absurd contradiction - since bitcoin was originally created precisely as a means of payment not controlled by the government.

Why has cryptocurrency, which was initially positioned as a convenient and independent means of payment, ultimately turned out to be impractical, expensive to use, and slow in transaction speed, while at the same time steadily enjoying the support of Western corporations and governments?

In my view, there are three key reasons:

The first reason lies in the sphere of monetary policy and fits perfectly within the framework of Milton Friedman's theory. Large volumes of the money supply require sterilization, and cryptocurrencies are ideally suited for this task. In essence, the capitalization of the crypto market reflects the volume of funds that was withdrawn from real circulation and, if necessary, can be easily and safely absorbed back by states.

The second reason is obvious, although publicly something quite different is declared. Cryptocurrencies are an excellent instrument of control and surveillance. Despite the formally declared anonymity of transactions, the owner of a crypto wallet can be identified much more easily than is commonly thought. All operations are transparent and forever recorded in an open ledger. Contemporary cryptocurrency is a kind of experimental testing ground for future state digital currencies, where all wallets will be rigidly verified and tied to persons. As a result, authorities will receive absolute control over financial flows, the movement of funds, and tax revenues. Bitcoin mining today is a prototype of the tax system of the future.

Finally, the third reason is the complete removal of responsibility from the state. On the one hand, crypto makes it possible to effectively sterilize the money supply, control shadow transactions, and lay the foundation for full-fledged digital control of citizens. On the other hand, governments bear no formal responsibility for this before the population. This is an ideal situation: maximum control with a complete absence of obligations.

The key point, of course, lies elsewhere: bitcoin is a field of thought. It is a structuralist development of the idea that we can create a currency out of thin air that will support itself only by means of a narrative.

Bitcoin conceptually realizes the very same concept of power - subjectless, exercising total control and at the same time removing responsibility from itself.

Crime

A revealing example of the totality of the postmodern field is the transformation of crime. It is important to say immediately: this is not about the organizers of new criminal networks having read Lyotard, Deleuze, or Foucault and consciously built "decentered" structures. Rather the opposite: the environment itself, the time itself, the dominant form of social organization itself produces such modes of action, which are then reproduced in all spheres - in business, politics, media, war, and even in crime.

This can be seen most clearly in the example of Japan. The classical yakuza was arranged as a criminal version of a modern organization: clan, hierarchy, elders and juniors, rituals, symbolism, territory, name, reputation. Even in the official description of the Japanese police, traditional organized crime groups are characterized as structures built around a "boss," a ranked order, relations of fictive kinship, and internal hierarchy.

That is why the old mafia was not only violent, but also readable. It had a face. It had an address. It had leaders. It had a reputation that could be lost. In the case of the yakuza, this was expressed even more strongly: tattoos, belonging to a clan, business cards, a ritual of atonement such as yubitsume. None of this makes the yakuza "good," but it shows that even old-type crime was included in the order of tradition, discipline, and responsibility. It was criminal, but not formless.

The state could fight such crime precisely because it was a subject. It could be described, localized, deprived of its channels of existence, struck at the hierarchy, the finances, the legal connections. In fact, the Japanese strategy against bōryokudan was largely built on social and economic displacement: the number of members and associate members of organized crime groups fell from 91,000 people in 1991 to 17,600 by the end of 2025; the Japanese police connect this decline with the effect of anti-bōryokudan legislation, strategic pressure, and the spread of practices excluding such groups from normal social and economic life.

But the disappearance of the old form does not mean the disappearance of crime. Another type comes in its place - tokuryū, that is, "anonymous and fluid criminal groups." This is no longer mafia as clan, but crime as network. Not lifelong belonging, but temporary assembly for a concrete task. Not "family," but workflow. Not a boss at the table, but a nickname in a messenger. Not a ritual of initiation, but the sending of a passport, a photo of the face, and an address, after which a person can be blackmailed and used as a disposable module.

The Japanese police describe this model almost in the terms of postmodernist theory itself: the core of the group is anonymized, roles are segmented, participants are weakly connected through social networks and job sites, and the lower level is constantly replaced - people are hired anew each time as "single-use" executors. In another place, the same report says directly: organizers give instructions through anonymous communication channels, while the immediate executors are "fluid" - for each crime new people are recruited through social networks, and after arrests they are replaced by the next ones.

The "Luffy" case shows this mutation well. In 2023 in Tokyo, in the city of Komae, criminals posing as couriers broke into the home of an elderly woman, tied her up, beat and robbed her; the woman died. The investigation showed that one of the executors entered the crime through an advertisement for criminal "side work" on social networks and received instructions from a person calling himself "Luffy," who was in an immigration center in the Philippines and managed operations through a smartphone.

Here the very ethics of crime changes in principle. The yakuza offered a young man a difficult, dangerous, but understandable life scenario: enter the organization, obey the elders, endure discipline, receive status, money, and protection. New crime offers nothing of the sort. It says: "just perform the task." Pick up a package. Call a pensioner. Register a card. Break a shop window. Pass on money. Receive payment. This is no longer a criminal fate, but a criminal microtask.

That is precisely why such crime coincides perfectly with the logic of postmodernity. It has no stable center, no obvious subjecthood, no code, no responsibility toward the executor. The executor does not become "one of us"; he becomes a consumable element. If he is caught, the system does not collapse. The goods have already been carried out, the money transferred, the data collected, the next executor found. The official report directly describes that such groups request driver's licenses, facial photos, and other personal data from applicants in order later to force them into crimes and prevent them from leaving the scheme.

Therefore it is more difficult to fight new crime. The old mafia could be attacked as an organization. The new one has to be caught as a process. It disintegrates and assembles again, changes communication channels, recruits through social networks, moves centers abroad, uses anonymous applications, electronic payments, and cryptoassets. The Japanese police directly acknowledge that traditional methods of struggle are insufficient: new interagency systems are being created for tokuryū because such groups operate at once through fraud, robberies, thefts, and other kinds of criminal financing.

It is precisely here that crime becomes a strong example of the general thesis. Postmodernity is not simply the disintegration of the old order. It is the emergence of a new order, which looks like disintegration only to someone accustomed to seeing order in the form of hierarchy, center, and stable organization. The yakuza was the criminal double of modernity: vertical, territory, name, discipline, symbolism, responsibility. Tokuryū is the criminal double

of postmodernity: network, anonymity, temporary contract, microtask, replaceable executor, remote center, and dissolved responsibility.

And this is the main point: criminals of the new type do not have to know the philosophy of postmodernity. They simply act inside a world that is already organized postmodernistically. The field of thought of the epoch turns out to be total: it restructures not only the university, art, media, or the corporation, but even crime. Where society shifts from subjects to processes, from hierarchies to networks, from responsibility to distributed impersonality, crime inevitably takes the same form.

War

Postmodernity changes the very form of war. Classical war of modernity presupposed a clear boundary between the state of peace and wartime, between the front and the rear, between the economy and combat actions, between military and civilian. War was declared, conducted by armies under the flags of states, and ended with formal peace or capitulation. It was a vertical, subject-like, hierarchical model - state against state.

In postmodernity this boundary is completely blurred. As the Chief of the General Staff of the Armed Forces of the Russian Federation, Army General Valery Gerasimov, precisely formulated back in 2013 in the article "The Value of Science in Foresight":

"In the twenty-first century, there is a tendency toward the erasure of distinctions between a state of war and peace. Wars are no longer declared, and once they have begun, they do not proceed according to the familiar template."

Gerasimov directly points to a change in the very nature of confrontation:

"The role of non-military methods in achieving political and strategic goals has increased, and in a number of cases their effectiveness has significantly exceeded the power of weapons."

"The emphasis of the methods of confrontation used is shifting toward the broad application of political, economic, informational, humanitarian, and other non-military measures, implemented with the involvement of the protest potential of the population."

"All of this is supplemented by covert military measures, including the implementation of information confrontation activities and the actions of special operations forces."

"Asymmetrical actions have become widespread, making it possible to neutralize the adversary's superiority in armed struggle. These include the use of special operations forces and internal opposition to create a constantly operating front across the entire territory of the opposing state, as well as informational influence, the forms and methods of which are constantly being improved."

Here postmodernity manifests itself in full measure. War turns into a play with symbols and fragments of meanings. What previously had stable meaning (who is the aggressor, who is the victim, where the border is, what democracy, freedom, sovereignty, Nazism are) becomes mobile, situational, and playful. Symbols are redefined, inverted, and assembled anew for the current task. "Color revolutions" are presented as a "spontaneous protest of civil society," and not as a planned operation. The boundaries between "internal conflict" and external aggression are deliberately blurred.

Power here acts through a subjectless network. There is no single visible order to "start the war." There is a distributed process - media, NGOs, social networks, "spontaneous" activists, PMCs, hackers, proxy forces. The subject (the client-state) dissolves into the protocol, algorithm, and narrative. Responsibility is blurred: "it was not us, the people rose up," "these are internal contradictions," "this is the market and freedom of speech."

Postmodernist war is no longer an event, but a permanent regime of influence on the opponent's entire social system. It proceeds continuously, even when "officially" no one has violated peace. The main weapon is the management of perception and the creation of chaos through the constant reassembly of meanings.

Postmodernity worked here as well: the West, which for decades actively used precisely such methods (the Arab Spring, color revolutions, information campaigns, sanction wars), renamed the analysis of its own actions the

"Gerasimov doctrine" and declared it Russian aggression. A classic postmodernist move: the description of reality was declared a threat to reality itself.

Conclusion

In all the examples considered, one and the same mechanism manifests itself: postmodern power does not so much renounce control as learn to exercise it without direct responsibility. Its strength lies not in crude command, not in open violence, and not in the classical vertical, but in the ability to organize the environment in such a way that control is preserved, profit is extracted, risks are shifted downward, and the subject of power remains partially invisible.

That is precisely why postmodernity cannot be understood only as the disintegration of meaning or the weakening of order. On the contrary, it produces a new order - more flexible, distributed, and therefore often more effective. But the key feature of this order becomes evasion of responsibility. Power no longer necessarily says: "I forbid," "I command," "I control." It acts differently: through the algorithm, protocol, platform, procedure, interface, rating, rules of access, rules of visibility, and the renaming of things themselves.

In social networks this appears especially clearly. A platform can control the information field, promote some authors, restrict others, reduce the visibility of undesirable content, block monetization, or completely exclude a user from the system. But at the same time it does not look like a classical censor. It covers itself with algorithms, community rules, private property, concern for safety, or freedom of speech. Formally, freedom is preserved: everyone can speak. In reality, what becomes decisive is not the right to speak out, but access to distribution, visibility, and audience. Censorship ceases to be called censorship, and precisely because of that becomes more effective.

The same logic operates in the platform economy and contemporary business. A company or platform increasingly shifts onto the worker what was previously the zone of responsibility of the entrepreneur: training, self-promotion, selling oneself, reputation, psychological resilience, readiness for risk, constant self-development. But profit, infrastructure, and the right to change the rules remain above. The worker must behave like an entrepreneur, but does not receive entrepreneurial power. He bears risks as an independent subject, while preserving dependence as a hired worker or platform user. Here there arises a characteristic postmodern simulacrum of freedom: a person is offered autonomy precisely in the form that makes him more governable.

In the financial sphere a similar mechanism manifests itself through distributed money and cryptocurrencies. Formally, crypto is described as liberation from the state, banks, and centralized issuance. But such a system can simultaneously be convenient for states, corporations, and security structures: it makes it possible to sterilize excess money supply, track transactions, experiment with digital forms of control, serve gray and criminal zones - and at the same time not take direct political responsibility. The state is as if "not involved": it does not issue this money directly, does not guarantee its users stability and security, but can use the environment itself in its own interests. This is an almost ideal postmodern situation: control is possible, profit is possible, responsibility is blurred.

In crime, the same principle is visible in the transition from classical mafia or yakuza to distributed networks. Old crime had a face: clan, hierarchy, boss, territory, code, reputation. New crime increasingly acts as a process: temporary executors, disposable tasks, remote curators, anonymous channels, microcontracts, blackmail through personal data. The organizer disappears into the network, while responsibility falls to the lower level - to the executor, the "drop," the courier, the accidentally drawn-in person. Crime becomes not a fate and not belonging to a clan, but workflow. This is crime without a stable subject, but not without organization.

Especially important here is the mechanism of renaming. Postmodern power works not only through procedures, but also through juggling with signs. It takes old concepts, destroys their moral and social weight, and then assembles new, more convenient meanings. Thus a dependent worker becomes a "partner," subordination becomes "engagement," the exploitation of personal time becomes "self-development," censorship becomes "moderation," exclusion from the system becomes a "violation of community rules."

A good example is OnlyFans. There occurs not simply the commercialization of sexuality, but its sign-based reformatting. Prostitutes or sex workers are called "creators," and consumers of sexual content are called "fans." The

very structure of relations is renamed so that the old moral and social weight of what is happening disappears. Instead of prostitution - creativity. Instead of a client - a fan. Instead of the exploitation of desire - the economy of self-expression. Instead of the owner of infrastructure extracting profit from sexualized dependence - a neutral platform for content authors.

It is precisely in this renaming that the power of postmodernity manifests itself. It does not necessarily prohibit the old morality directly. It makes it irrelevant through a change of language. The moral, psychological, and social consequences remain with the users: with those who sell their intimacy, with those who consume this content, with those who become dependent on the platform, attention, money, desire, and digital visibility. But profit and control remain with the owners of the network. Responsibility is blurred because formally everyone is free: some freely create content, others freely pay, the platform only provides a technical possibility. But precisely this "neutral possibility" is a form of power.

Therefore the main mechanism of postmodernity can be described as follows: power becomes less subject-like, but not less strong. It moves from the direct master to the protocol, from command to environment, from ideology to interface, from prohibition to the management of visibility, from morality to renaming. It exists on the boundary between subjecthood, supra-subjecthood, and subjectlessness.

On the one hand, behind platforms, corporations, financial systems, and media there still stand concrete owners, interests, and groups of influence. On the other hand, the system itself can no longer be reduced to the will of one subject. It operates as a supra-subject machine: through industrial standards, algorithms, markets, legal regimes, corporate processes, and cultural codes. And at the limit it begins to look almost subjectless: as if no one governs the whole, but the whole nevertheless reproduces power, control, and the distribution of benefits.

Here an important boundary arises with radical theories such as Nick Land's. In Land, this thought is taken almost to the limit: subjectless power is thought as an inhuman force, as if future artificial intelligence or the capitalist machine is already assembling itself in advance through the present. Within the framework of this work, there is no need to accept this thesis literally. But the very formulation of the question is important: contemporary power increasingly looks not like the will of a ruler, but like the self-assembly of processes, where people, corporations, platforms, algorithms, and desires become elements of a larger machine.

That is precisely why postmodernity turns out to be a productive system. It does not simply destroy old meanings, but creates new regimes of governance. Its productivity consists in the fact that it knows how to produce power without an obvious holder of power, control without direct command, exploitation without open coercion, censorship without a censor, a moral shift without the recognition of moral responsibility.

If modernity built power through the subject, the vertical, ideology, and discipline, then postmodernity builds it through the protocol, the network, the procedure, renaming, and distributed irresponsibility. It masks control as freedom, dependence as self-realization, exploitation as partnership, censorship as moderation, prostitution as creatorship, the consumer as a fan, and power as the neutral operation of the system.

The final thesis can be formulated as follows: postmodern power is power that does not disappear, but removes itself from the zone of responsibility. It becomes stronger precisely because it ceases to be directly visible. Its subject does not always disappear completely, but it hides behind protocols, platforms, algorithms, markets, signs, and procedures. Therefore postmodernity is not an epoch of weak power, but an epoch of power that has learned to act as freedom.